

# The Explorer's Journal

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Day 1.

They said no one ever found what the old crafter left behind. I intend to prove them wrong.

The forest is quiet. Somewhere out here a chest waits, sealed tight against thieves and time.

I have nothing yet but my wits and these two empty hands.

# The Explorer Tent

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An old tent, half-swallowed by the brush. Someone lived here once, and left in a hurry.

A little iron. Some odds and ends. And a lump of something red tucked beneath the pillow. Strange thing to hide. I'll keep it.

In the corner, a chest wrapped tight in chains.

# The Compass

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A traveler is lost without a  
needle to trust.

The old notes speak of markers  
in the trees. I'll follow them  
and see where they lead.

The path from here:

# The Waypoint

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The markers led true.  
A cache, hidden well beneath  
the roots -- someone stocked  
this place and never returned.

Rough stone, cool and heavy,  
and a thick bundle of blank  
paper, still dry after all  
this time.

The woods grow thicker here,  
and quieter.

# The Old Mine

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The dark smells of cold rock  
and older things.

Deep in the tunnels: cobwebbed  
string, a warm glint of copper,  
and a seam of black coal in the  
stone.

Scratched by the entrance, a  
drawing -- the whole valley,  
laid flat as a page.

# The Map Awakens

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The drawing came alive in my hands. Ink spreading like water, showing me everything.

A stream. A cave mouth. A scar of stone where the earth was dug deep. And a figure, far off, waiting.

Odd -- pale grains scattered along the water's edge.

# The Stream

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The map led me to the water's edge.

Someone fished here once -- their tacklebox still rests on the bank, half-rotted. A length of line inside, and a note on how to build a rod.

The water is deep and dark.  
Something glints beneath the surface, just out of reach.

# Diamonds!

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The water gave up its secret.

Diamonds -- three of them, cold  
and bright as ice, dripping in  
my palm.

I have never held anything so  
hard, or so beautiful.



## The Ancient Quarry

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The deep stone yielded at last.

A green jewel, bright as spring,  
and iron besides -- good, heavy  
iron for a blade.

The trader will want to see  
this green one, I think.

## The Villager's Trade

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He took the green jewel gladly,  
and pressed something into my  
hand in return -- a shard of  
purple crystal, cold and  
glittering.

Then he spoke plainly for once.  
"Darkness guards what you seek.  
Bring light, and bring a  
blade."

Light I can manage -- coal, and  
the old torch note from the  
tent. But an edge worthy of the  
dark? That I still need.

# The Dark Cave

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Old marks cover these walls,  
cut deep by a frightened hand.

They warn of a creature -- a  
silent, swollen thing that  
keeps to the trails and does  
not sleep.

They say it can be seen from a  
height, by one with the eyes  
for distance.

# The Creeper Falls

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There -- on the path below,  
green and waiting.

My blade ended it. What it left  
behind: a fine black powder,  
the kind that sleeps until it  
wakes all at once.

The pale grains by the stream.  
The chains on that chest.  
I am beginning to understand.